FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Everyone moves from one place to another. Have you ever wondered how and why Indians travel? Now, there's an answer to that question. The first-ever National Household Travel Survey, with a sample size of nearly 500,000 units, was commissioned to map that path. The Railways has been asking for precisely such a macro planning tool since 2020, for all past data was patchy or derivative. This week, Team India Today overlays it with data from the Domestic Tourism Expenditure Survey, July 2025-June 2026, to knit together the big picture. What emerges is both compelling and troubling.

One quarter of the way into the 21st century, what dominates is not hypermodernity, or our ham-handed attempts at attaining that. It's good old mass, and often in surprising ways. Among Indians travelling a kilometre or more to work, just 3 per cent use cars. As many as 42.6 per cent rely on two-wheelers. And 28.3 per cent actually walk. The pyramid shows up in another category: buses still take 55.8 per cent of those who travel overnight. Only 17.7 per cent take a train, 15.1 per cent go by car, and a measly 0.6 per cent board a flight. Such nuggets, fascinating as well as sobering, come to us from these two national surveys with a combined sample size of nearly 750,000. Many patterns give us cause for optimism. They tell us something the planners have overlooked: the distance between our infrastructure ambitions and our mobility realities. This is how India moves in 2026. A diagnosis that must take us to a better place.



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Indians have been exhibiting a growing appetite for travelling for reasons other than work. One big trend line there would be the least surprising: faith moves us the most. Accounting for 47.7 per cent of the four travel reasons covered, pilgrimage tourism has, literally, arrived. Those clambering on to that bus to Tirupati now include, surprisingly enough, honourable members of Gen Z. But pilgrimages do not depart from the broad trajectory. Rather, they share experiential and economic traits with leisure, health and shopping travel. The larger question that arises from all of them is the same: are we planning and building transport around real needs or around abstract ambitions?

Consider why India mostly goes to the office on two wheels. Cars convey just 3 per cent of work travellers nationally, and 5.7 per cent in cities; motorcycles and scooters are the primary mode for 42.6 and 52.3 per cent, respectively. Their appeal is obvious: door-to-door mobility, flexible timings, and the ability to thread their way across several destinations. But convenience also carries a heavy cost: two-wheeler users accounted for 81,780 deaths in 2024, or 46.2 per cent of road fatalities. Why, then, do Indians buy scooters? Because the undependable public transport leaves them no choice. In sprawling cities where miles separate home and work, the bus does not show up. So, the scooter does.

The solution is not mysterious. India has wasted years building flyovers over other flyovers, privileging cars as the first citizen of the roads. Now we must do what the data demands: invest seriously in mass transport. Sizeable fleets of well-appointed buses, metro lines and smaller modes, all linked up in a seamless, single-ticket system, will join two vital imperatives: cross-city travel as well as last-mile connectivity. Only this will help hapless two-wheeler users and motorists off the roads, reduce overall costs of commuting, as well as ease nightmarish congestion and vehicular pollution. Also, help close the gender gap: presently, only 41.9 per cent female workers report work journeys of a kilometre or more, against 61.9 per cent men. This model of safe and plentiful public transport can also make some kerbside space for that most human way of travelling: walking.

Beyond the daily commute, 35 per cent of rural and 38 per cent of urban households make overnight trips for leisure, health, shopping or religious reasons. But leisure makes up 36.4 per cent of urban trips, and only 12.5 per cent of rural trips. Medical travel accounts for 38.4 per cent of rural journeys. There's unevenness of other kinds too. Pilgrimages may have become the biggest component in size. Still, they tot up an average expenditure of only Rs 7,694 per trip, the lowest among the four purposes. This is beginning to change. Almost 71 per cent of pilgrimage rooms booked are still priced below Rs 4,500 per night, but premiumisation is gaining momentum. In FY25, bookings in the Rs 7,000-10,000 range and those above grew by 24 and 23 per cent, respectively. The industry is experimenting with converting temple visits into cultural journeys encompassing heritage, food and wellness. But only a few sites, like the urban regeneration projects steered by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at Varanasi and Ayodhya, have worked on upgrading infrastructure to earn their footfalls. What remains work in progress are more expansive hybrid circuits that link up cities, blending faith and leisure, with hotel infrastructure to back them.

Our cover story this week digs into this goldmine of data for the interesting new ideas lurking within, like the '15-minute city'. Eventually, we will get there, but for now wander through these numbers. They hold the key to how India should move.

Meanwhile, wishing you happy and safe travels in this festive season!

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